

Radio Plays for Semantic Elicitation

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Mom: You still have some on your plate. Finish eating the salad!

Son: I don't want to eat any more salad. I'm done eating the salad.

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Mom: You still have some on your plate. Finish eating the salad!

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Mom: Okay, go and study.

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(Could he say "I ate up the salad."? No, I don't think so.)

~~Mom: Okay, go and study.~~

Mom: Okay, work on your schoolwork.

A mom and a son are talking.

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(Could he say "I ate up the salad."? No, I don't think so.)

~~Mom: Okay, go and study.~~

Mom: Okay, work on your schoolwork.

Son: I'm finished with my schoolwork too!

A mom and a son are talking.

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Son: I don't want to eat any more salad. I'm done eating the salad.

(Could he say "I ate up the salad."? No, I don't think so.)

~~Mom: Okay, go and study.~~

Mom: Okay, work on your schoolwork.

Son: I'm finished with my schoolwork too!

Mom: You never listen to me when I talk to you!

1. Circumscribing and Situating Radio Play Elicitation
2. Where We're Coming From
3. Theoretical Utility
with Advice
4. Agility and Speed
with Advice
5. Benefits for Consultants' Workload
with Advice
6. Summary

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What I mean by “Radio Play Elicitation”

- A targeted dialogue translation task.
- Most/all crucial context is actually spoken by characters in the dialogue.
- Co-constructed with consultants one line at a time.
- At any given moment in the dialogue, alternative sentences can be presented for additional judgments.
- At the end, the entire dialogue is read out in the target language.

Contrasting with Related Methodologies

Translation task

- Unlike storyboard (Burton & Matthewson, 2015)
- Unlike mini-storyboard (Johnson, 2024)

Without pictures

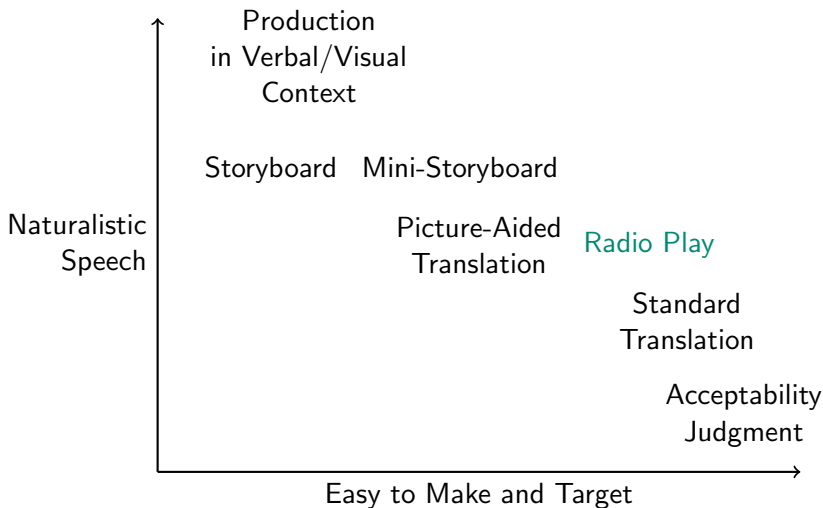
- Unlike picture aided translation / storyboard with words (Bochnak & Matthewson, 2020; Nouri-Hosseini, 2018)

Dialogue

- Unlike standard elicitation translating contexts (Cover, 2015)
- Unlike standard elicitation with story arc (Louie, 2015)

Comparable to a flexible, targeted conversational questionnaire (François, 2019)

Continuum of Targeted Semantic Elicitation Methodologies



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Tlingit (en: 'kɫɪŋ.kít; tli: *Lingít* [ʔɪn'kít]) language

- Indigenous
- Northern Pacific Northwest of North America
- Alaska and Canada political contexts

A couple dozen fluent speakers exist.

- Most over 80 years old
- Mixed literacy in Tlingit
- All fluent and literate in English

Fieldwork Context



Fieldwork sessions:

- Teslin, YT and Wrangell, AK
- One to three consultants at a time
- Elicitor(s) an outside linguist (LB) and/or a Tlingit linguist & learner (JC)
- Sometimes other community members also present
- Whiteboard

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Targeted Elicitation

As with any targeted semantic elicitation (Bochnak & Matthewson, 2020; Cover, 2015; Matthewson, 2004):

- Explicit context helps control how consultants interpret prompts.
- Allows collecting negative data.
- Targeted creation allows testing specific hypotheses.

Presenting contexts one line at a time allows building up complex contexts gradually; similar benefit to storyboards (Burton & Matthewson, 2015).

E.g.:

Susan: *What is your son doing with that butterfly net?*

Peter: *He's trying to catch a butterfly.*

Susan: *There are no butterflies this time of year.*

Peter: *He doesn't know that there are no butterflies. He's still trying to catch one.*

It matters whether butterflies exist, and whether the agent knows it. Establishing these is easy in a gossippy dialogue.

C.f. Similar task by Crane (2024) for complex temporal reference.

Eliciting Dialogue as a Genre

Dialogue + Targeted contexts = Middle ground between spontaneous conversation and isolated judgment tasks. Similar benefit to conversational questionnaires (François, 2019).

E.g.:

A little boy, Alex, is looking out the window.

Alex: *Look at all those sticks outside! I'm gonna gather them up for my fireplace.*

→ *Latín áwé sheey aadé dax yakoogéiyi yé. Aax shí yak_kasahéin ax x'aan eetí yís.* (SJ, MB)

Alex: *Mom, look at these sticks I got for our fireplace!*

→ *Atlée, latín yá sheey haat xwali.át haa x'aan eetí yís.* (SJ, MB)

It would be hard to find *atlée* “Mom!” in natural dialogue.

General Targeted Elicitation Advice

Some advice for storyboards applies (Burton & Matthewson, 2015):

- Combine multiple targets in one story.
- Include a few variations on one construction.
- Make the stories funny.
 - This is harder than it looks! Sitcom mindset.

Also, have in mind an ending for the story.

- Good chance for a punchline.

Drawback: Naturalness of Translation

Any translation task decreases naturalness of elicited speech, a drawback for language documentation.

Tradeoff in exchange for closer control over what structures are found (c.f. picture-aided translation; Nouri-Hosseini, 2018).

Unnatural (and yet grammatical and felicitous) sentences can still be informative, e.g. from Fox (1999):

Every one of these problems seems to a different teacher to be likely to be solved by John.

A final target-language read-through helps mitigate unnaturalness. Can also lead to paraphrases providing additional insight.

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Radio plays are extremely easy to make.

It suffices to come up with a bullet-point outline for a story and improvise the dialogue.

E.g.:

During a fieldwork trip, I realized I needed to check whether a pluractional form entailed a non-pluractional perfective. I wrote down *kid breaking sticks - can't break them - says "I'm breaking [pluractional] but haven't broken one"* and told the story the next day.

Easiness is extremely important for highly endangered languages where there isn't much time to do fieldwork (Johnson, 2024).

Even bigger advantage when fieldwork trips are short and compressed.

E.g.:

I wanted to test a hypothesis on seven different pluractional suffixes, each of which has a restricted set of verbs it goes with. Radio plays allowed me to make stories with verbs from each class, without having to figure out how to draw them all.

Using radio plays is also fast, because the time setting up contexts doubles as collecting data.

Radio plays are co-created dynamically with consultants.

Important if a consultant objects to the planned story on cultural grounds, or if they don't have a word for one of the story elements.

E.g.:

Kid: *Give me a book to read!*

Librarian: *This book is good for kids.*

Kid: *I don't want it. I'm already ten years old. I only want to read books for adults!*

Consultant comment (SJ): I wouldn't say adults, it would be teenagers.

Participating in writing the story is fun for some consultants.

Prepare for Agility

Be aware of syntactic constraints for words that might come up if the story changes, so you can propose well-formed alternatives for judgment.

You can also include syntactically revealing forms in the story.

E.g.:

In Tlingit, imperatives let you predict many other verb forms, so I often include imperatives in radio plays. Then, if I get an unexpected verb, I can still manipulate it correctly to try alternative forms.

Keep a clear idea of your targets, so you know how flexible to be.

Tradeoff with replicability: A conversational-questionnaire style uses a more rigid story, but allows easy replication (François, 2019).

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Easy to get Consultants on Board

Translation is fairly intuitive, and dialogue context takes pressure off for finding a word-for-word mapping.

Setup portion of dialogue helps train newer consultants (c.f. Ferreira & Müller, 2022).

Stories are fun (Louie, 2015), and consultants participate in creation.

E.g.:

Julia is trying to cut a carrot. The knife won't go through.

Julia: *I'm trying to cut this carrot.*

Consultant comment (SJ): Ok, just to make it up...

Sharpen this knife!

For highly endangered languages, extra important to be enjoyable for consultants.

Lightens Working Memory Load

Some consultants have trouble holding a whole context in their heads.

Holding context in mind is easier if it's a story (Louie, 2015).

Having consultants translate relevant context makes it more salient to them (Johnson, 2024). Radio plays incorporate this idea, since the context is in the dialogue to translate.

Especially relevant for elderly consultants, and hence for highly endangered languages (Johnson, 2024).

Keeping Track of the Story

Agility means that the story can change quickly.

To help keep track:

- Record the story-so-far on a shared whiteboard or paper.
- Frequently read aloud through the story-so-far to refresh.
- Keep an eye out for signs that the consultant thinks the story is inconsistent.

E.g.:

Narrator: *She cooked a giant pot of soup.*

Narrator: *She spent one hour dicing up a hundred potatoes.*

Consultant comment (MB): The story's getting mixed up. Cutting the potatoes should have come before she made that pot of soup.

Keeping Track of Story Characters

Remembering characters is harder than in picture-based elicitation.

E.g.:

At a craft fair.

One seller: *I'm packing up my bracelets. Are you ready to go?*

Other seller: *I still haven't sold any necklaces.*

Consultant comment (SJ): Up there you already were packing, how does that come out again?

Can be mitigated:

- Do different voices when reading aloud.
- Give characters distinct names - e.g. Annie and Bob, not John and Jane.
- Use relationships which are easy to say in target language.
- Use different colors to transcribe each character.

Hard to Skip Around in the Story

When asking for judgments on alternative sentences, it's hard to go back to an earlier moment in the story.

It's easiest to only move forward in time - like conversation in real life.

Tradeoff in exchange for lowering working memory load.

So either

- get the judgments you need on the first pass through the story, or
- start the whole story again - maybe on another day.

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- Radio play elicitation uses dialogues co-constructed and translated with consultants one line at a time.
- They are quick to make and run, which is vital for short fieldwork trips or languages with few speakers.
- They can be easy for consultants in terms of working memory and the format of the task.
- This trades off with reproducibility and naturalness.

Format lends itself to future language-learning materials.

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McGill

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